

**NT6242: Sermon on the Mount**

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**Week #9 Essay: Language of Sermon on the Mount**

Should the Sermon on the Mount be viewed different from the rest of scripture? For example, the book of Acts is viewed as literal history, but should we spiritualize the SM so that we view it as a hyperbole and not something that we actually need to follow? When it says, “Be perfect as your Heavenly Father is perfect,” do we need to actually become perfect? I want to try to answer some of these questions in this paper. By quoting five different sources, I want show that the consistent and correct interpretive style of the SM should be consistent with the rest of the Bible - literal, historical-grammatical, meaningful, and realistic.

According to Jones,<sup>1</sup> we have some insight into how the Sermon on the Mount should be interpreted. According to my method, once again, I say that it should be a literal approach that says that things are accomplished on this earth, and are accomplished soon and in the present.

Jones says that Leviticus 19 has strong connections with the Sermon on the Plain, which is found in Luke. This is a strong indication that Jesus is quoting the Old Testament, which means that he believes that the Old Testament is literal and true, and should be quoted as a means of reference as scientific literature.

Therefore, we can be sure that Jesus’ sermon is also scientific-grade literature and that we can quote it like the Old Testament. It means that we can view it as a literal interpretation.

An example of this is, “love your neighbor as yourself” (Leviticus, Sermon on the Mount, Jones).

Also, Jones says, “element of justice appears both in the SP and the SM,” which means that this sermon is very scientific in its style of quoting, and thus, we can say that it is a literal interpretation, rather than a figurative approach.

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<sup>1</sup> Jones, Peter Rhea. “Jesus’s New Covenant: The Holiness Code and the Sermons on the Mount and Plain.” *Perspectives in Religious Studies* 51, no. 4 (2024): 435–43. EBSCOhost.

And finally, we see that the verse in Leviticus says, “You shall be holy, for I the Lord your God am holy,” (v.2) which is a reflection of the verse, “Be perfect, as your Heavenly Father is perfect” (Matthew). As we can see again, the Gospels reflect the Old Testament, and we know that the Old Testament is interpreted literally.

We see a striking similarity with Luke, in the Sermon on the Plain, when it says, “Be merciful as your Father is merciful” (Luke). This further shows that we have corroboration in a scientific manner.

According to Ridlehoover,<sup>2</sup> the Sermon on the Mount reflects the character and person of Peter, the disciple of Jesus. “Peter’s depiction is tied to Jesus’s first sermon,” says Ridlehoover.

“Sermon on the Mount paint a picture of Peter as embodying all the highs and lows of the Matthean Sermon, especially the Two Ways discourse (Matt 7:13–27).” This shows that the SM has a lot of ups and downs that depict the bipolarity of Peter’s character.

As we can remember, Peter’s character is bipolar - going from high faith to low faith - almost immediately. For example, he says, “Lord, let me walk on the water with you!” And right when he steps out, he cries out, “Lord save me!”

And he says “Lord, I will die with you.” And within, I believe, 24 hours, he denies him three times.

Peter’s character is one of bipolar-ness, and is what is depicted in the SM and may have inspired the SM.

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<sup>2</sup> Ridlehoover, Charles Nathan. “The Matthean Peter: Peter as Archetype and Antitype of the Sermon on the Mount.” *Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society* 64, no. 4 (2021): 729–44. EBSCOhost.

But how does this relate to our question of interpretation? We can see that since the SM is based on a real person, Simon Peter, the SM is supposed to be realistic and thus interpreted literally. It is a Christian text, and is not supposed to be just a moral text that is a guide for any person or religion. It is to be strictly interpreted as a Christian text, that has its foundation in reality, such as Simon.

According to Machinek,<sup>3</sup> we see that the SM has been “often either spiritualized and understood as private guidelines for moral heroes, or merely as certain images that constitute an invitation to make radical choices, without the intention or commandment to follow any specific conduct.”

We see here that Machinek is saying that the SM has been viewed as a spiritualized text that is not realistic or literal. That it is over exaggerated and its hyperboles are meant to stimulate and make an invitation to “radical choices,” but it’s not actually the case that we need to make them because they are just there to stimulate us.

This is completely incorrect as Machinek will say later in his paper - that the interpretation style of the SM should be literal.

Machinek says,  
 disconnecting the SM “from the entirety of his message, which itself can be properly understood only in the context of the entire biblical tradition. The New Testament must be seen as the final cleansing and clarification of the contents of the Old Testament faith. As Lohfink emphasizes, Christian theology sees the New Testament as a kind of a “final redaction” (Schlussredaktion) of the Old Testament.”

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<sup>3</sup> Machinek, Marian Szczepan. “Gerhard Lohfink’s Interpretative Key to the Sermon on the Mount.” *Verbum Vitae* 39, no. 4 (2021): 1335–1355. <https://doi.org/10.31743/vv.12864>

What this is saying is that the SM cannot be treated as separate from the rest of the Bible and be the only text in the Bible that is viewed spiritually and not literally. The rest of the Bible, such as the Old Testament, as was seen in Leviticus, is interpreted literally, and thus, the SM should be interpreted literally as well.

This is the same argument that was made with source one in this paper, and thus, we have a recurring argument, which means that multiple sources are saying the same thing, which supports each other. This is a strong argument.

According to Viljoen,<sup>4</sup> we see that “South Africa is widely regarded as one of the most violent countries in the world...The violence in the country is associated with socio-political conflicts, civil unrest and racial polarisation, among other things.”

It may seem that this fact is unrelated to this paper, but we shall see that South Africa is “a country where many citizens claim to be Christians.” How can a country with so many Christians be so civilly unrest? Is the SM literal or is it just garbage?

If the SM is literal and has the power of the Holy Spirit, it should be able to change a country like South Africa, right? What can be the connection between the SM and all the violence in South Africa? This seems like a contradiction.

I can make speculations, but I can assure you that the SM has the power to change South Africa, and the violence in SA is not due to the fact that the SM has no power and is not literal. Thus, it must be that the gospel is not being preached correctly in South Africa, and that the South African people are not following the SM correctly.

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<sup>4</sup> Viljoen, Francois P. “A Call for Peacemaking: A Perspective from the Sermon on the Mount.” *In Die Skriflig* 55, no. 2 (2021): 1–8. <https://doi.org/10.4102/ids.v55i2.2708>.

If we do more research, it is possible that the SA people view the SM as a spiritual text, and do not have strong theology. What we see throughout the early centuries of the church, is that we have martyrs that give up their lives for the gospel and do not fight back. We even have military chaplains and medics who are Christian and do not fight in war. These real world examples show us that the SM is literal and has the power to change reality, and thus, can be viewed and interpreted as real and literal.

According to Argarate, a 4<sup>th</sup> century text says that there are two types of commandments Jesus gave, major commandments and minor commandments. The major ones make us Perfect and the minor ones make us upright. He says,

“Lord Jesus Christ gave major and minor commandments, and how one can distinguish Perfection from Uprightness, and that through the major commandments one becomes Perfect and through the minor ones Upright.

This separation between major and minor commandments show that there is an order and meaning to the SM, and that the SM is not to be viewed as just a general commandment. There are nuances, there a grades or levels of importance to each thing that Jesus says. This must surely mean that the SM needs to be interpreted literally.

And because this text was written in the 4<sup>th</sup> century, we can tell that it has a strong support by the Christian community because the earlier a text is, the more closer to the time of Jesus it was made. Thus, we can be confident that a literal, and meaning, and realistic interpretation of the SM is the correct interpretation.

In conclusion, there were five sources that support the meaningful, literal, and non-spiritualized interpretation style of the Sermon on the Mount. It is consistent because we should always interpret it this way, and there is not a time when we can deviate from it. The main reason

is: Leviticus is the basis for the SM, and the Old Testament has been viewed literally by the Jews and Christians. The SM is not different from the rest of the the New Testament or the Old, and thus, should be interpreted with the historical-grammatical approach - in other words, literal approach.

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